THE DOCTRINES OF GRACE

FOREKNOWLEDGE
PREDESTINATION
ELECTION

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Doctrines of Grace

- As such we will be covering the following doctrines of grace:
  - The Holiness of God
  - Creation, Fall, and Nature of Man
  - **God's Foreknowledge, Predestination, and Election**
  - The Atonement
  - Regeneration
  - Justification, Faith, and Grace
  - Sanctification
  - The Preservation and Perseverance of the Saints
  - Glorification

Golden Chain of Redemption (or not?)

Romans 8:28–29 (ESV)

28 And we know that for those who love God all things work together
for good, for those who are called according to his purpose. 29 For
those whom he **foreknew** he also **predestined** to be conformed to the
image of his Son, in order that he might be the firstborn among many
brothers. 30 And those whom he predestined he also called, and those
whom he called he also justified, and those whom he justified he also
glorified.

Foreknowledge

- **προγινώσκω (proginosko, verb) –** to know beforehand or in advance, have foreknowledge, to choose beforehand
  - Romans 8:28
- **πρόγνωσις (prognosis, noun) –** foreknowledge, predetermination
  - Acts 2:23; 1 Peter 1:2

- A critical question: *What does foreknowledge mean?*

Foreknowledge

- Romans 8:18-36

Foreknowledge

- Three options for interpreting *foreknowledge* in Romans 8:29 (as far as I know):

1. Those whom God foreknew were those who God knew before in history, the nation of Israel.
2. God knows all future events, even how humans will choose based on their own will.
3. God knows His elect in a salvific manner and predestines them.

Option 1 and Romans 8

Romans 8:28–30 (ESV)

28 And we know that for those who love God all things work together for good, for those who are called according to his purpose. 29 For those whom he **foreknew** he also predestined to be conformed to the image of his Son, in order that he might be the firstborn among many brothers. 30 And those whom he predestined he also called, and those whom he called he also justified, and those whom he justified he also glorified.

- According to this view, in 29, Paul begins to talk about the people of Israel which God knew before hand
- The argument is that Paul is trying to encourage us by looking back at the people of old that God called

Option 1 and Romans 8

- They point out that all the verbs in 29 are past tense verbs (aorist active indicatives)
- They will say the most basic way of reading foreknowledge is "something known in times past"

“Christians, don’t worry we know (from past experience) that God always works out everything for those who love God and are called to follow Him. If you want proof, look at those God previously knew, loved & called in the past, He determined them to be conformed to the image of His Son, so that His Son would become the firstborn of many brethren.”

Leighton Flowers, 06:07, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5aqR23SrHy0

Option 1 Issue A

Romans 8:28–30 (ESV)

28 And we know that for those who love God all things work together for good, for those who are *called according to his purpose*. 29 For those whom he foreknew he also predestined to be conformed to the image of his Son, in order that he might be the firstborn among many brothers. 30 And those whom he predestined *he also called*, and those whom he called he also justified, and those whom he justified he also glorified.

- The entire chapter is about the believer all the way through
  - Verses 29-30 would be the only part of this encouragement not about believers
- The called in verse 30 are same as the called in verse 28

Option 1 Issue B

Romans 8:28–30 (ESV)

28 And we know that for those who love God all things work together for good, for those who are called according to his purpose. 29 For those whom he foreknew he also predestined to be conformed to the image of his Son, in order that he might be the firstborn among many brothers. 30 And those whom he predestined he also called, and those whom he called he also justified, and those whom he justified he also glorified.

- Verses 12-17 tell us that we have received the Spirit of adoption
- Because we have been adopted in Christ, Christ is our elder brother
- This is not true of the people of Israel before Christ
- This is a clear reference to the adoption language in verses 12-17 which is about believers

Option 1 Issue C

- Romans 11:1–2 (ESV) - 11 I ask, then, has God rejected his people? By no means! For I myself am an Israelite, a descendant of Abraham, a member of the tribe of Benjamin. 2 God has not rejected his people whom he **foreknew**. Do you not know what the Scripture says of Elijah, how he appeals to God against Israel?
- They will look at this verse and say this is the same as in chapter 8
- Let’s read Romans 11:1-10

Option 1 Issue C

- If the foreknown in chapter 11 are the same as the foreknown in chapter 8, then why has God rejected them?
  - That really takes away from the whole purpose of chapter 8, doesn't it?
- 2 options here:

1. Foreknowledge in chapter 11 is referring to the remnant which God had "chosen by grace" which would then be the same as the foreknowledge in Romans 8
2. Foreknowledge is different from Romans 8 and is *actually* talking about the nation of Israel which God has hardened

- The point Paul is making is that God has not rejected His people Israel, but has kept a remnant

Foreknowledge

- Three options for interpreting *foreknowledge* in Romans 8:29 (as far as I know):

1. ~~Those whom God foreknew were those who God knew before in history, the nation of Israel.~~
2. God knows all future events, even how humans will choose based on their own will.
3. God knows His elect in a salvific manner and predestines them.

Foreknowledge – Noun Verses

- Acts 2:23–24 (ESV) - **23** this Jesus, delivered up according to the definite plan and **foreknowledge** of God, you crucified and killed by the hands of lawless men. **24** God raised him up, loosing the pangs of death, because it was not possible for him to be held by it.
- 1 Peter 1:1–2 (ESV) - **1** Peter, an apostle of Jesus Christ, To those who are elect exiles of the Dispersion in Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia, **2** according to the **foreknowledge** of God the Father, in the sanctification of the Spirit, for obedience to Jesus Christ and for sprinkling with his blood: May grace and peace be multiplied to you.

Foreknowledge – Verb Verses

- Acts 26:5 (ESV) - 5 They **have known** for a long time, if they are willing to testify, that according to the strictest party of our religion I have lived as a Pharisee.
- 2 Peter 3:17 (ESV) 17 You therefore, beloved, **knowing this beforehand**, take care that you are not carried away with the error of lawless people and lose your own stability.
- 1 Peter 1:20–21 (ESV) - 20 He was **foreknown** before the foundation of the world but was made manifest in the last times for the sake of you 21 who through him are believers in God, who raised him from the dead and gave him glory, so that your faith and hope are in God.
- Romans 11:2 (ESV) - 2 God has not rejected his people whom he **foreknew**. Do you not know what the Scripture says of Elijah, how he appeals to God against Israel?

Examples of Foreknowledge

- Are there any examples of God foreknowing someone in a specific sense?

Jeremiah 1:4–5 (ESV)

The Call of Jeremiah

4 Now the word of the LORD came to me, saying,

5 "Before I formed you in the womb I knew you,
and before you were born I consecrated you;
I appointed you a prophet to the nations."

“

Galatians 1:14–16 (ESV)

14 And I was advancing in Judaism beyond many of my
own age among my people, so extremely zealous was I for
the traditions of my fathers. 15 But when he who had set
me apart before I was born, and who called me by his
grace, 16 was pleased to reveal his Son to me, in order that
I might preach him among the Gentiles, I did not
immediately consult with anyone;

”

Foreknowledge of Christ

- 1 Peter 1:17–21 (ESV)
- 17 And if you call on him as Father who judges impartially according
  to each one's deeds, conduct yourselves with fear throughout the
  time of your exile, 18 knowing that you were ransomed from the
  futile ways inherited from your forefathers, not with perishable
  things such as silver or gold, 19 but with the precious blood of Christ,
  like that of a lamb without blemish or spot. 20 **He was foreknown
  before the foundation of the world but was made manifest in the
  last times for the sake of you** 21 who through him are believers in
  God, who raised him from the dead and gave him glory, so that your
  faith and hope are in God.

Foreknowledge of Christ

- Christ was crucified according to the will of God (see Lesson 3 - Creation and Providence Slides)
- Did God just foresee Christ's and His obedience, or was Christ Himself foreknown by God?
- What about the crucifixion?
  - Was that something God foresaw?
  - Was it God's plan?

Thinking through Foreknowledge

- As we consider foreknowledge in Romans 8, we must also consider God's foreknowledge in everything (they are the same conversation)
- Does God bring things about because He foresees that it will happen?
- Or do things come about because of the foreknowledge of God?
- Do things prophesied come true because God saw it would happen in the future or because that was God's will and He was going to bring it about?

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Paragraph 1
God the good Creator of all things, in His infinite power and wisdom does uphold, direct, dispose, and govern all creatures and things, from the greatest even to the least, by His most wise and holy providence, to the end for the which they were created, according unto His infallible foreknowledge, and the free and immutable counsel of His own will; to the praise of the glory of His wisdom, power, justice, infinite goodness, and mercy.

”

1689 Baptist London Confession, Chapter 5.

“

Paragraph 2
Although in relation to the foreknowledge and decree of God, the first cause, all things come to pass immutably and infallibly; so that there is not anything befalls any by chance, or without His providence; yet by the same providence He ordered them to fall out according to the nature of second causes, either necessarily, freely, or contingently.

”

1689 Baptist London Confession, Chapter 5.

“

Paragraph 3
God, in his ordinary providence makes use of means, yet is free to work without, above, and against them at His pleasure.

”

1689 Baptist London Confession, Chapter 5.

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Paragraph 4
The almighty power, unsearchable wisdom, and infinite goodness of God, so far manifest themselves in His providence, that His determinate counsel extends itself even to the first fall, and all other sinful actions both of angels and men; and that not by a bare permission, which also He most wisely and powerfully binds, and otherwise orders and governs, in a manifold dispensation to His most holy ends; yet so, as the sinfulness of their acts proceeds only from the creatures, and not from God, who, being most holy and righteous, neither is nor can be the author or approver of sin.

”

1689 Baptist London Confession, Chapter 5.

Paragraph 5

The most wise, righteous, and gracious God does often times leave for a season His own children to manifold temptations and the corruptions of their own hearts, to chastise them for their former sins, or to discover unto them the hidden strength of corruption and deceitfulness of their hearts, that they may be humbled; and to raise them to a more close and constant dependence for their support upon Himself; and to make them more watchful against all future occasions of sin, and for other just and holy ends. So that whatsoever befalls any of His elect is by His appointment, for His glory, and their good.

1689 Baptist London Confession, Chapter 5.

Paragraph 6

As for those wicked and ungodly men whom God, as the righteous judge, for former sin does blind and harden; from them He not only withholds His grace, whereby they might have been enlightened in their understanding, and wrought upon their hearts; but sometimes also withdraws the gifts which they had, and exposes them to such objects as their corruption makes occasion of sin; and withal, gives them over to their own lusts, the temptations of the world, and the power of Satan, whereby it comes to pass that they harden themselves, under those means which God uses for the softening of others.

1689 Baptist London Confession, Chapter 5.

“

Paragraph 7
As the providence of God does in general reach to all creatures, so after a more special manner it takes care of His church, and disposes of all things to the good thereof.23

”

1689 Baptist London Confession, Chapter 5.

Primary and Secondary Causes

- God is the only primary cause of all things; nothing would happen apart from Him (2LBC; Chapter 5; paragraph 1)
- However, His will is accomplished through secondary causes (2LBC; Chapter 5; paragraph 2)
  - Ephesians 1:11 (ESV) - **11** In him we have obtained an inheritance, having been predestined according to the purpose of him who works all things according to the counsel of his will

Which comes first?

- Are things unfolding because God foresaw them or because God has created the ends of this world and the means in which those ends are accomplished?
- Do things in this world unfold on their own or do they happen within the providential care of the Father?
- Do we really believe God feeds even the sparrow (Matthew 6:25-34)?
- Do we really believe that we don't have a pastor right now because it is God's will?
  - Or is it because of disagreements on the search committee?

“*Every day, Christians express their commitment to this doctrine. When you bow your head to pray before a meal, you thank God for the food He provided for you. This is an acknowledgment that the good things we enjoy, such as our daily bread, come to us from God. He is the first cause as He upholds, disposes, directs, and governs His creatures and their actions. And yet we know that the food before us does not miraculously appear. It is rather the result of a long series of creaturely actions, beginning with a seed planted in the ground, growth through watering and the nourishment of the soil, harvesting, transportation, and so forth. The delicious salad you enjoy comes to you through many steps, and usually involves many people to bring it to you. And yet you thank God as if He directly provided it to you. And in reality, He did in providence, decreeing in eternity that those plants would produce for your nourishment, upholding their vitality and growth in this world, and sustaining everyone involved in the planting, nourishment, harvesting, and delivery of that food to you. It is quite appropriate to thank Him for the food, while recognizing that the Lord uses providential means to accomplish His decree.*”

James H. Renihan, *To the Judicious And Impartial Reader,* Baptist Symbolics Volume 2, p. 154.

What comes first?

- We love these doctrines in good things, but not in the bad things
- When negative or evil happens, we pretend as if God was not provident over that event
- It is a real issue when it comes to sin
  - Did sin enter this world apart from the foreknowledge of God?
  - Did God just foresee sin?
  - Was Christ's death not God's decree?
  - Was sin then part of God's will for the end of this world to bring about the sacrifice of Christ through secondary means?
- These are the questions that I wrestle with

The Mystery of Foreknowledge

- Ultimately, these things are mysterious to us
- I do not have all the answers to your questions
- Where the Bible stops speaking, so do I
- Not all are satisfied with appealing to mystery

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Soteriology101 @Soteriology101

If the only recourse you have to deny the obvious logical entailments of your theological claims is to punt to mystery, feign outrage or accuse your opponents of nefarious intentions/lacking intelligence etc, then you’re contributing to the problem, not providing any solutions.

”

The Mystery of Foreknowledge

- Every side of this debate is left with questions we cannot answer
- The mystery is what makes this doctrine so difficult
- Ultimately, we have to trust God and not get consumed by the details
- However, this does not mean it is not important, and the debate should not happen
- What you believe about the sinful condition of man and the foreknowledge of God impacts the rest of your soteriology

Foreknowledge in Soteriology

- Does God foreknow that someone will choose Him or does God foreknow them in a salvific sense?
- Your answer to this question determines what predestination and election mean
- It also has a major impact on your view of the atonement
  - Did Christ die for every individual?
  - Did Christ die for those who we foreknew?

Predestination and Election

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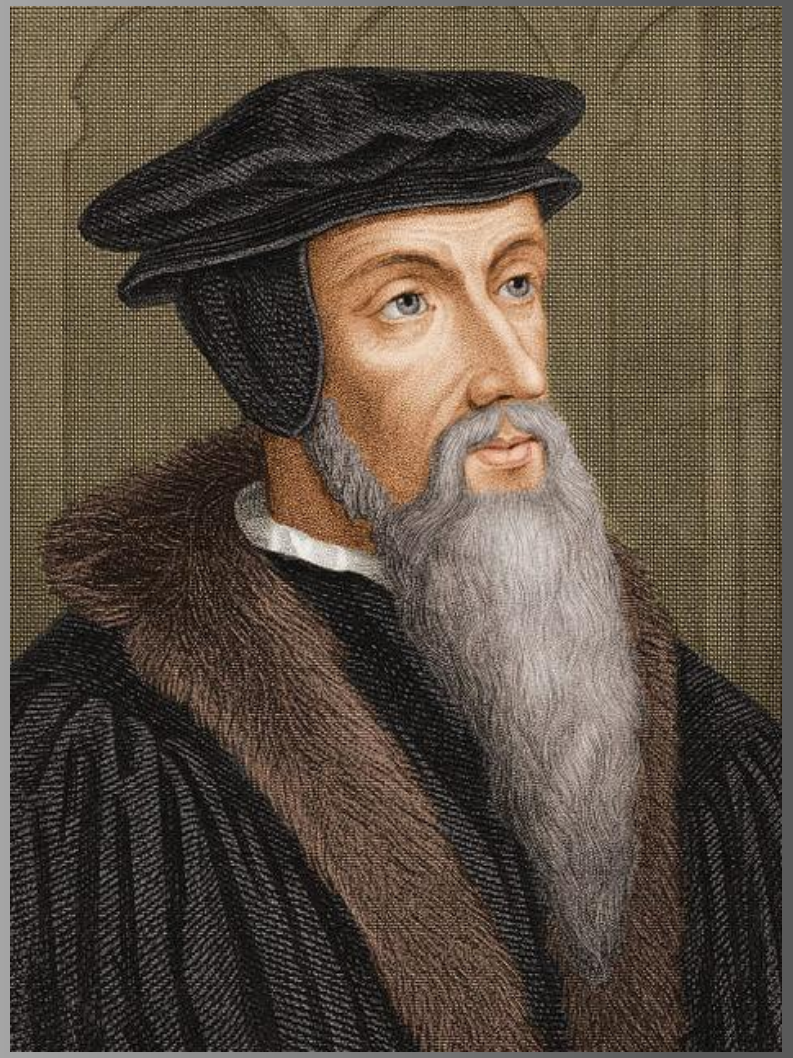
First, then, let them remember that when they inquire into predestination they are penetrating the sacred precincts of divine wisdom. If anyone with carefree assurance breaks into this place, he will not succeed in satisfying his curiosity and he will enter a labyrinth from which he can find no exit. For it is not right for man unrestrainedly to search out things that the Lord has willed to be hid in himself, and to unfold from eternity itself the sublimest wisdom, which he would have us revere but not understand that through this also he should fill us with wonder. He has set forth by his Word the secrets of his will that he has decided to reveal to us. These he decided to reveal in so far as he foresaw that they would concern us and benefit us.

”

John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, ed. John T. McNeill, trans. Ford Lewis Battles, vol. 1 & 2, The Library of Christian Classics (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox Press, 2011), 922–923.



The doctrine of the high mystery of predestination is to be handled with special prudence and care, that men attending the will of God revealed in His Word, and yielding obedience thereunto, may, from the certainty of their effectual vocation, be assured of their eternal election; so shall this doctrine afford matter of praise, reverence, and admiration of God, and of humility, diligence, and abundant consolation to all that sincerely obey the gospel.

1689 London Baptist Confession, 3.7

Golden Chain of Redemption (or not?)

Romans 8:28–29 (ESV)

- 28 And we know that for those who love God all things work together for good, for those who are called according to his purpose. 29 For those whom he foreknew he also **predestined to be conformed to the image of his Son, in order that he might be the firstborn among many brothers. 30 And those whom he predestined he also called**, and those whom he called he also justified, and those whom he justified he also glorified.

Definitions

- *Predestination* - **Προορίζω (Proorizo)** – decide upon beforehand, predetermine

- *Elect* - **ἐκλογή (Ekloge)** – a special choice, selection, election

- There is no debate around the meaning of these words because these are the definitions of these words
- Two questions are asked:
  - Who is predestined and elected?
  - What are they predestined and elected unto?

  1. Is predestination and election "conditional, corporate, and to service, not salvation"? (Leighton Flowers, "Election Means 'To Choose'", https://soteriology101.com/2022/02/22/election-means-to-choose/)
  2. Is predestination and election unto salvation?

Two Ways of Thinking

- There are two common different ways of looking at predestination and election:
  1. Is predestination and election "conditional, corporate, and to service, not salvation"? (Leighton Flowers, "Election Means 'To Choose'", https://soteriology101.com/2022/02/22/election-means-to-choose/)
  2. Is predestination and election unto salvation?

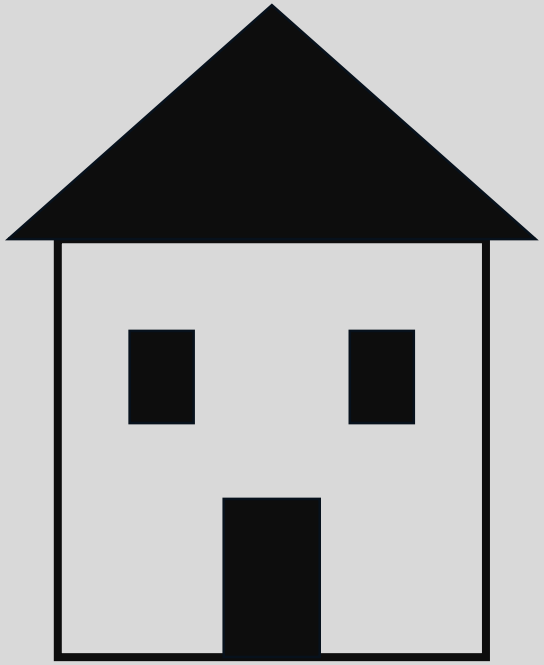
Option 1 – Conditional Election

- "Individuals are not elected and then put in Christ. They are in Christ and are therefore elect."
  - Snodgrass, Klyne. (1996). The NIV Application Commentary (p. 84). Zondervan, Grand Rapids, Michigan.
- "Christ is the principal elected one, and the corporate body included in him consists of the ones God has chosen."
  - Klein, W. W. (2015). The New Chosen People: A Corporate View of Election (Revised and Expanded Edition, p. 154). Wipf & Stock.

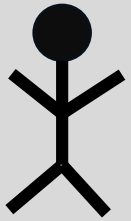
- In this view of predestination and election, our election is conditioned by our choice of God
- We become the elect once we are in Christ and all who are in Christ are predestined to all the things the Bible says we are predestined unto

Option 1 – Conditional Election

IN CHRIST



NOT ELECT



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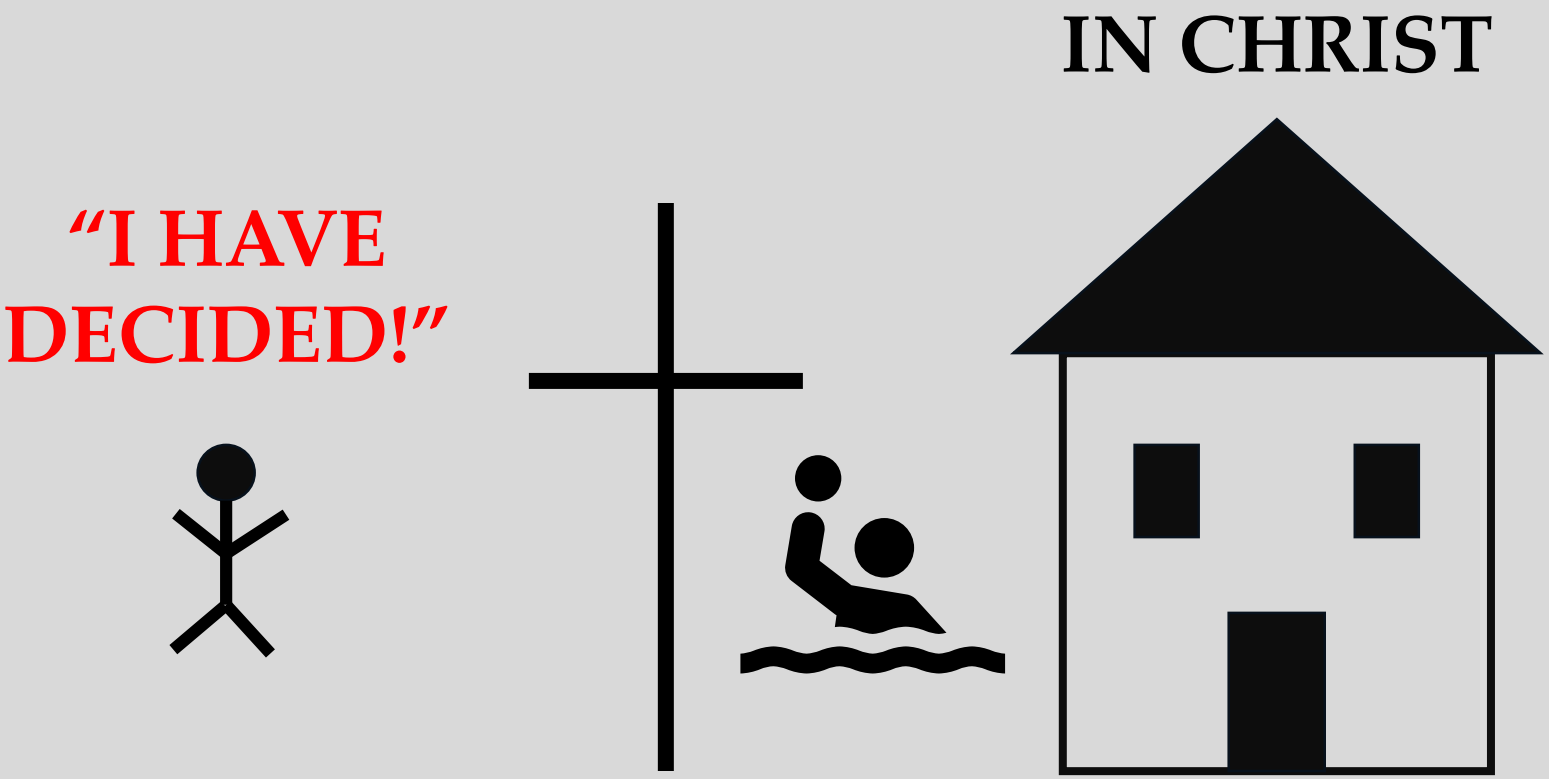

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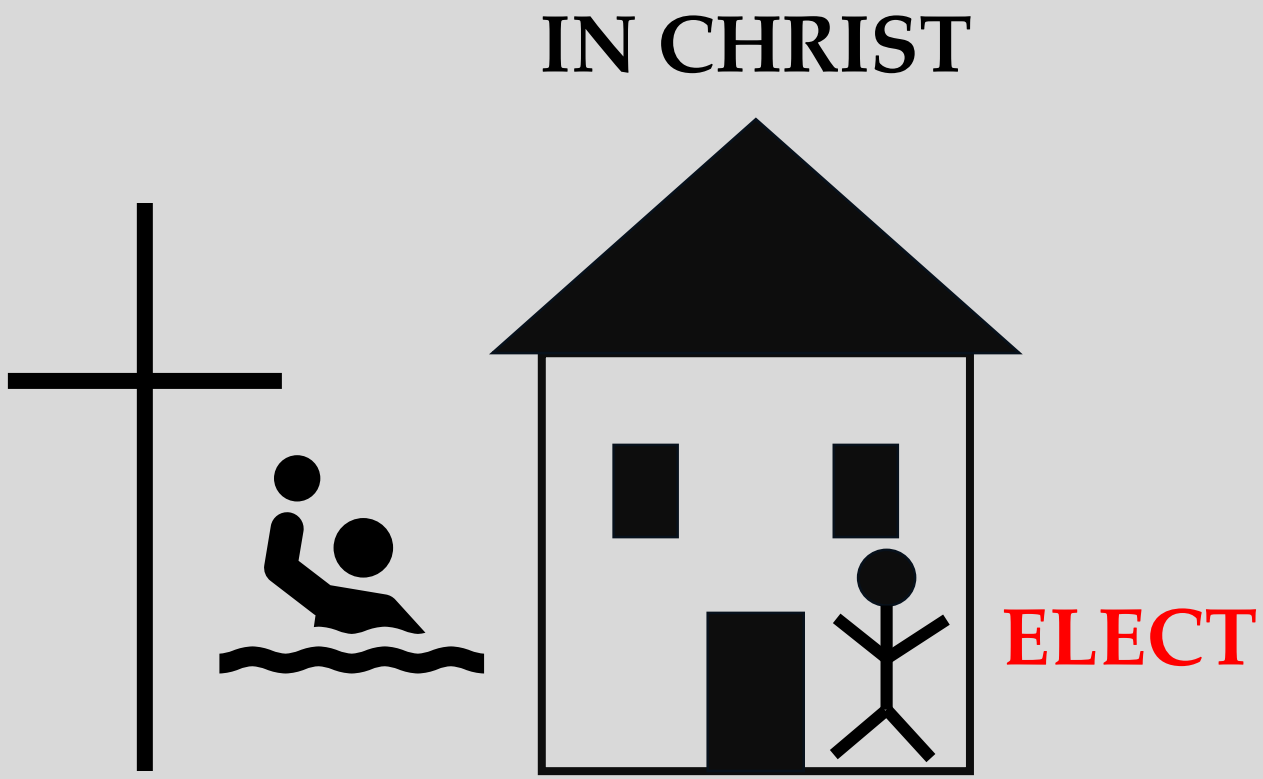


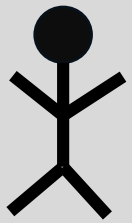
Option 2 – God's Election

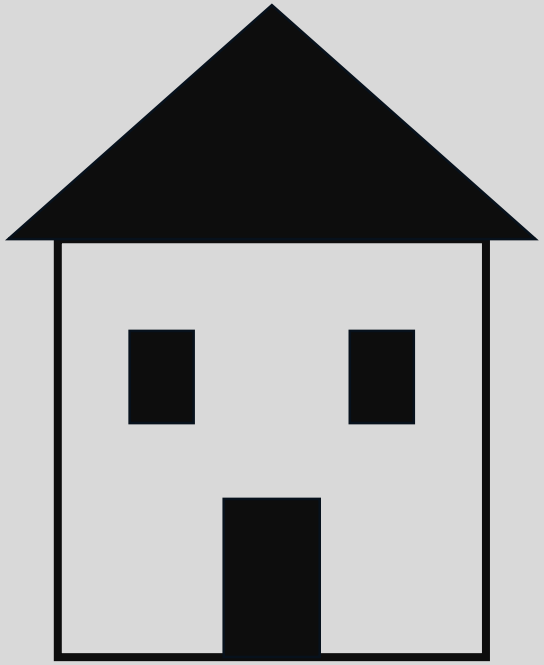
- Our election and predestination is based on God's choice
- Some call this "unconditional election"
  - It is unconditional only in the sense that God's choice is not dependent upon my works or actions, but only on God's mercy and grace
  - This can often be misrepresented to mean "that God's election to salvation does not involve a genuine human response or, even worse, that God elects some people irrespective of Jesus' atoning death on the cross." (Timothy George, *Amazing Grace: God's Pursuit, Our Response)*

Option 1 – Conditional Election

IN CHRIST

ELECT





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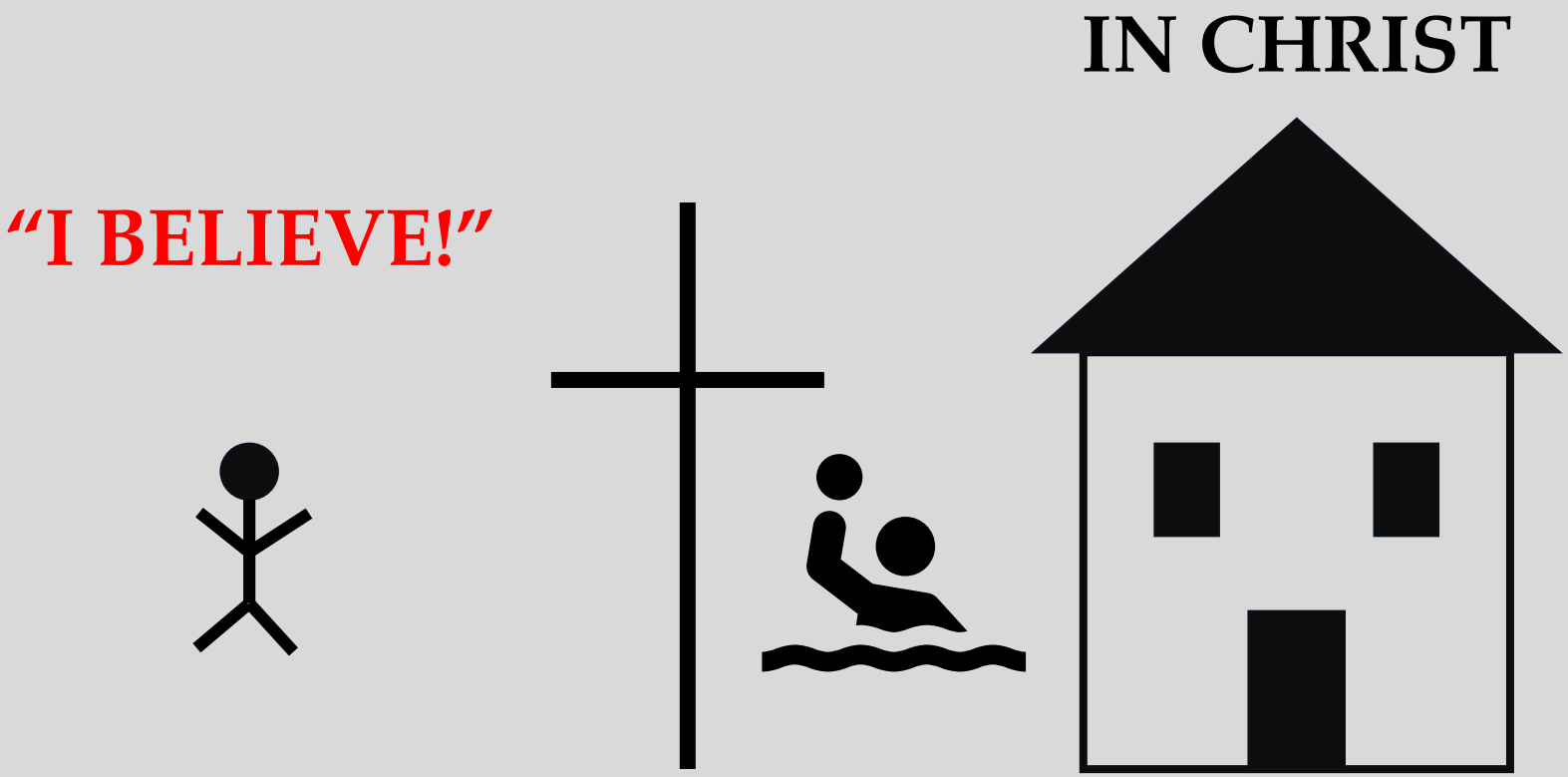
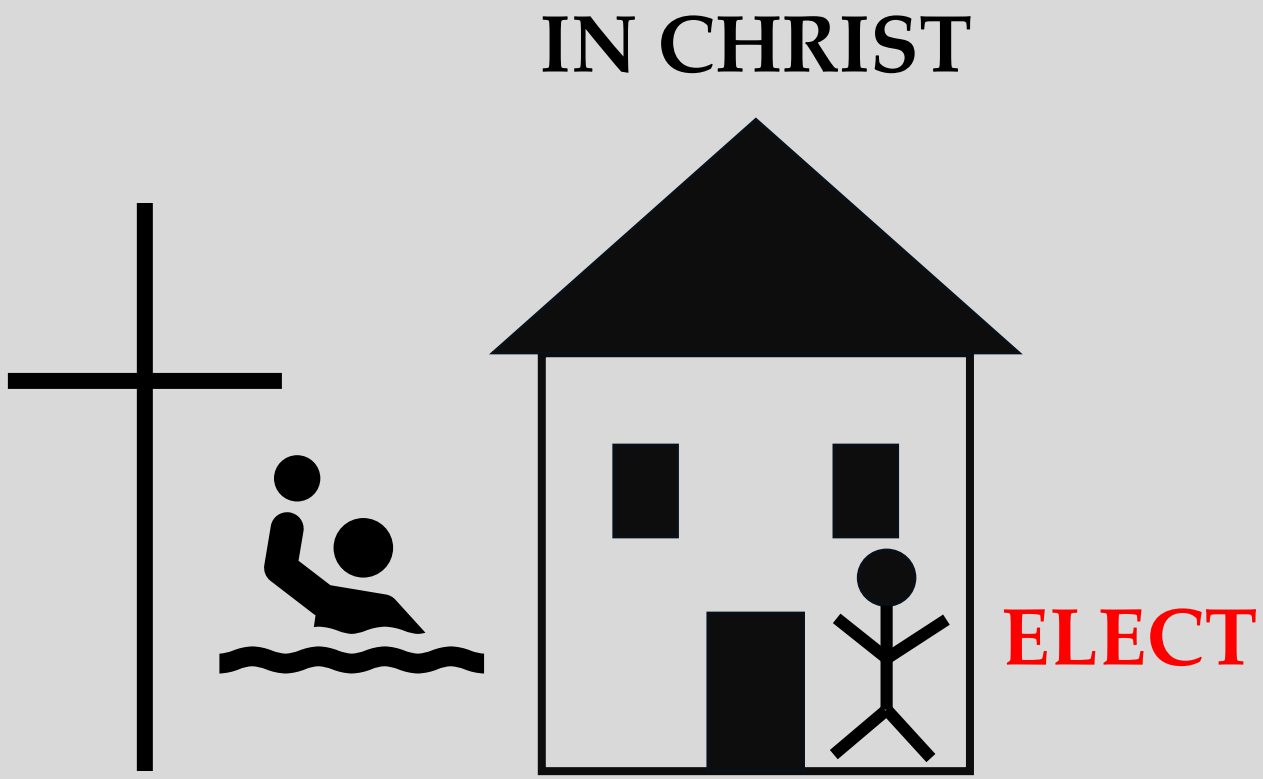
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